

7.5 Anti-virus Software



Anti-virus software are a must on any networked system

As discussed earlier, being connected to any network means being in the line of fire from any individual intent on creating mischief or harming your system. Some of the most common forms of attack are by viruses or worms - these can cause widespread damage in a very short while.

Nowadays, all personal computers and networks are protected by utilities such as anti-viruses and firewalls. A typical anti-virus is software that has a two-pronged approach to tackle any attack or suspected activity: the dictionary definition method and the suspicious behaviour approach.

In the dictionary definition approach, the anti-virus examines a file and refers to the latest virus definitions loaded on the system. After this it either deletes the infected file, or quarantines it so the virus cannot spread, or attempts to repair the file. For your system to be safe it is imperative that you update your virus definitions on a regular basis. Any individual who is somewhat technically inclined can send files that they think are infected by a new virus, to anti-virus software writers for inclusion into the definitions.

The suspicious behaviour approach does not attempt to identify known viruses, but monitors the behaviour of all programs. If one program tries to write data to an executable program, for